grew. ‘ *We lucked out.* It was *luck* that prevented nuclear war in the Cuban missile crisis.’[49] These views were shared by many others. Captain Ryurik Ketov, the commander of the B-4 in 1962, believed that ‘Mere chance prevented Savitskii from resorting to the use of “special weapons” at this time.’[50] Martin Sherwin describes the crisis as ‘history’s luckiest non-event’.[51] An increasingly sophisticated literature has developed that explores the philosophical as well as practical dimensions of luck in the nuclear age, and which reinforces anxiety about the risk of inadvertent nuclear war.[52]

Malign and beneficent luck

What if Henry Stimson had not persuaded Harry Truman to remove Kyoto from the target list? What if Nagasaki was not added to the target list? What if Truman had decided to halt or pause the atomic attacks to see the Japanese response to Hiroshima or until after the Soviet entry into the war? What if the skies over Kokura on 9 August were clear? What if Commander Ashworth had decided not to bomb Nagasaki by radar and aborted the attack before the break in the clouds? What if Major Sweeney decided his fuel was too low for an attack on the secondary target? In any of these counterfactuals Nagasaki would have been spared. The greater our awareness of such contingences, the greater our sense of the appalling luck suffered by the people of Nagasaki. Conversely, the greater our awareness of the events of October 1962, the greater our sense of the great good luck enjoyed by humanity in the Cuban missile crisis.

Horsepersons of the Apocalypse

Since Sir David Attenborough delivered his warning on climate change in 2018, more immediate threats to global society emerged. The World Health Organisation estimated that between January 2020 and December 2021 the Covid-19 pandemic killed nearly fifteen million people, and fears that a more lethal and contagious strain of the virus could emerge continue to